that we must seek the explanation for the rapid development of the Quad. In the case of Japan and Australia, the relationship that India had was much thinner both in content and scope. Where the US was concerned, there were some sectoral strengths in an overall substantive but differentiated engagement. But even these had their limitations.

In the last decade, India's systemic interface with its Quad partners expanded very significantly. It extended across many more domains and enabled a full spectrum engagement with them. Naturally, the challenges and opportunities were different in each case. But as they gained traction, lessons and experiences from one were helpful to the advancement of the others.

The Rediscovery of America

Let us start with the US. The current phase of ties with India can be traced back to President Bill Clinton's visit in 2000. The background may have been of the effective management of the political consequences of the 1998 nuclear tests. But the driver was more a coming together in a globalizing world. It is essential that this starting point be duly recognized because it confirms that India and the US upgraded their engagement seeing an intrinsic value in doing so. This was the era of the dotcom revolution and H1B visa. American dominance was quite pronounced globally and there was really no 'balance of power' argument that was driving the changes. It was, in fact, the improving prosperity, expanding talent and a larger global exposure of India that made it a better partner in American eyes.

In many ways, this was a natural progression of the relationship once the constraints of the Cold War era receded. Suggesting, as some do, that these ties do not have their own merit and must necessarily be directed against others is a mind game being played to discredit both the relationship and the Quad. This is all the more contestable, given how those making such charges have leveraged their own relationship with the US so enthusiastically in the past when it suited them. Obviously, when a judgement is proffered by a party with a stake in the outcome, it must be seen for what it is.

Progress in India–US ties accelerated during the Bush administration, which correctly identified the nuclear impediment as a major obstacle to serious cooperation. By this time, both sides wanted a more normal